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THE ELECTION

"Put three Zionists in a room and they will form four political parties."

Levi Eshkol

Benjamin Netanyahu was in a tailspin. It was the eve of a closely-fought election, a ballot that he had once seemed the clear favorite to win, but months of bad press and personal scandals had chipped away at this sense of inevitability. Israelis were tired of their leader, already the country's second longest-serving prime minister. Suddenly the man dubbed "King Bibi" seemed in real danger of losing his throne.

The election was on a Tuesday. The final round of pre-election polls, published on Friday—Israeli law prohibits releasing polls in the last four days—showed his Likud party trailing its main center-left challenger, the Zionist Camp, by four seats. One survey had them dipping as low as twenty mandates in the 120-member Knesset, a damning indictment of the ruling party.

So he panicked. On Friday night he logged on to Facebook and posted a long screed against Noni Mozes, the wealthy publisher of *Yediot Aharonot*, Israel's largest paid daily (and no fan of the prime minister). "The public needs to know the truth," he said. "Noni Mozes is leading a timed and orchestrated campaign against the Likud, and against me." Hours earlier, during a public question-and-answer session, he warned that "the governments of Western Europe, especially in Scandinavia, are funding the campaign that is designed to oust me from power." The self-proclaimed leader of the Jewish people seemingly missed the irony of accusing wealthy businessmen and sinister media barons of organizing a global conspiracy against him.

Notoriously media-averse—he once went 411 days without speaking to Israeli journalists—Netanyahu suddenly organized a last-minute media